Daily Bible Note

Date: 2026-11-08

I. Today's Reading

NKJV: Amos 3:9-15

9 "Proclaim in the palaces at Ashdod, and in the palaces in the land of Egypt, and say: 'Assemble on the mountains of Samaria; see great tumults in her midst, and the oppressed within her.

10 For they do not know to do right,' says the Lord, 'Who store up violence and robbery in their palaces.'"

11 Therefore thus says the Lord God: "An adversary shall be all around the land; He shall sap your strength from you, and your palaces shall be plundered."

12 Thus says the Lord: "As a shepherd takes from the mouth of a lion two legs or a piece of an ear, so shall the children of Israel be taken out who dwell in Samaria—in the corner of a bed and on the edge of a couch!

13 Hear and testify against the house of Jacob," says the Lord God, the God of hosts,

14 "That in the day I punish Israel for their transgressions, I will also visit destruction on the altars of Bethel; and the horns of the altar shall be cut off and fall to the ground.

15 I will destroy the winter house along with the summer house; the houses of ivory shall perish, and the great houses shall have an end," says the Lord.

II. Key Summary

• The Lord tells them to proclaim in the palaces of Ashdod and Egypt, calling them to assemble on the mountains of Samaria and see the great tumults and the oppressed; those who store up violence and robbery in their palaces do not know to do right (vv. 9–10).

• An adversary will surround the land and plunder Israel's palaces; the children of Israel in Samaria will be taken out like the two legs or piece of an ear a shepherd takes from the mouth of a lion (vv. 11–12).

• In the day the Lord punishes Israel, He will also visit destruction on the altars of Bethel, and the horns of the altar will be cut off; the winter house, summer house, houses of ivory, and great houses will be destroyed (vv. 13–15).

III. Passage Analysis

Calling the Nations to Watch

> The prophet invites the leading figures of Philistia (Ashdod was a Philistine city; the Greek translation reads "Assyria") and Egypt to come and see the evil of the northern kingdom. This summons is meant to catch the hearers' attention, and it is also deeply ironic—even the leaders of other nations, themselves full of evil, are called to look at the northern kingdom, which shows how shocking Israel's sin had become. [1]

In the previous section (3:1-8) the Lord said that of all the families of the earth He knew only Israel; now He has it proclaimed in the palaces of Ashdod and Egypt, calling them to the mountains of Samaria to "see great tumults in her midst, and the oppressed within her" (v. 9). Ashdod belonged to Philistia, which had just heard its own judgment in chapter 1 (1:6-8).

The people God knew had sinned so greatly that even the nations could see it plainly.

Nothing They Relied On Would Hold

> Some are at ease, but there will come a day of visitation, and in that day, all they are proud of, and put confidence in, shall fail them. [2]

Verse 10 says they "store up violence and robbery in their palaces"; in verse 11 the Lord says, "your palaces shall be plundered." The horns of the altar at Bethel in verse 14 were where a fugitive held on for protection [1], yet they "shall be cut off and fall to the ground." In verse 15 the winter house, the summer house, the houses of ivory, and the great houses "shall have an end."

The wealth they stored up, the altar they used as a refuge, the comfortable houses they lived in—on that day, none of it would last.

Note: When Did These Things Happen?

• Samaria (v. 9): The city was originally built by King Omri (1 Kings 16:24). [1]

• The altar at Bethel (v. 14): Jeroboam I set up golden calves and an altar at Bethel to replace Jerusalem (1 Kings 12:28-33) [1]; a man of God announced that altar's end at the time (1 Kings 13:1-5). [3]

• Houses of ivory (v. 15): King Ahab built an ivory house (1 Kings 22:39); large amounts of ivory used to decorate furniture and palace walls have been excavated at Samaria. [1][4]

• Later:

  ◦ Israel: Less than 30 years after Amos's prophecy, Assyria invaded Israel; a little more than ten years later, Israel was completely conquered and the people were scattered throughout the Assyrian Empire [5]. In 722 BC, Samaria fell to the Assyrian army of Sargon II. [1]

  ◦ The altar at Bethel: King Josiah of Judah later tore down the altar at Bethel (2 Kings 23:15). [3]

IV. Reflection Question

When trouble comes, what is the first thing you reach for—the thing that makes you feel "as long as I have this, I'm safe"?

The Israelites stored up violence and robbery in their palaces (v. 10) and lived in winter houses, summer houses, and houses of ivory (v. 15); the Lord said that in the day He punishes Israel, the horns of the altar at Bethel will be cut off and the great houses shall have an end (vv. 14–15).

References

[1] 華人基督徒查經資料網站 (Chinese Christian Bible Study), Amos Chapter 3 Notes (《串珠聖經註釋》，《啟導本註釋》, 唐佑之《天道聖經注釋 – 阿摩司書》，《舊約聖經背景注釋》), https://www.ccbiblestudy.org/Old%20Testament/30Amos/30GT03.htm

[2] BibleHub, Matthew Henry Concise Commentary (Amos 3:9-15), https://biblehub.com/commentaries/amos/3-14.htm

[3] BibleHub, Commentaries on Amos 3:14 (Barnes' Notes on the Bible, etc.), https://biblehub.com/commentaries/amos/3-14.htm

[4] BibleHub, Pulpit Commentary (Amos 3:15), https://biblehub.com/commentaries/amos/3-15.htm

[5] Enduring Word, David Guzik, Amos 3 – The Logic of God's Judgment, https://enduringword.com/bible-commentary/amos-3/